

SUPPLEMENT TO
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Annual Series

No. 18a

March 15, 1915

TURKEY,
HARPUT.

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TO COMMERCE REPORTS DAILY CONSULAR AND TRADE
REPORTS: TURKEY, HARPUT ***

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The limited trade of the Harput consular district has almost entirely ceased since the outbreak of the European War. Under normal conditions the trade is small and confined to the merest necessities of life. Stoves, bedsteads, dining tables, table linen, individual tableware, and many other articles usually regarded as indispensable in domestic life are not to be found even in the homes of the better classes.

Limited Business Opportunities—Population.

There are no manufacturing establishments or industrial enterprises of any importance and no business houses of any size in the entire district. The only stores are small shops or booths of one room, seldom more than 10 or 15 feet square and usually even smaller than that. The business of any one merchant is necessarily small, and the quantity of goods that he can handle limited. The goods are usually obtained by him through business connections in Constantinople or Aleppo. The district is essentially agricultural, and the products of the soil supply nearly all the needs of its inhabitants.

The Vilayet of Mamouret-ul-Aziz, in which Harput is situated, is said to contain about 500,000 inhabitants, of whom 250,000 reside in the Sandjak

of Mamouret-ul-Aziz, 180,000 in the Sandjak of Malatia, and 70,000 in the Sandjak of Dersim. Of the total number, about 90,000 are Christians and the remainder Mohammedans. There are nearly 3,000 villages in the Vilayet but no large cities. In addition to the Vilayet of Mamouret-ul-Aziz, four other Vilayets depend on this consulate—Sivas, Diarbekir, Bitlis, and Van. This comprises the greater part of the interior of Asia Minor, a region as large as all New England and New York combined, with a total population of about 3,000,000.

Lack of Transportation and Other Facilities—Trade Routes.

There are no railroads, tramways, electric light or gas plants, public telephones, places of amusement, automobiles, or newspapers in the entire district. The lack of means of transportation is the greatest hindrance to the development of the country. There are not even any navigable rivers in the district. The distance to any seaport is 200 to 400 miles, and all goods have to be brought here over extremely rough, mountainous roads, which are never kept in repair. In times of peace some goods are transported in crude carts, but at all times the greater part is carried on the backs of camels or donkeys. Transportation is thus always a matter of many weeks and often of months, especially in the winter, when the roads are frequently blocked by snow for two or three months.

The principal trade route in the district begins at Samsun on the Black Sea and runs southeast to Bagdad, passing through Sivas, Harput, and Diarbekir. Goods destined for this Vilayet usually come via Samsun, which is about 372 miles from Harput. This port being inaccessible at the present time, the few articles that come here are brought overland from Constantinople via Angora and Sivas or by mule trail from Alexandretta. Little merchandise has been received during the last few months. Freight rates are, of course, extremely high at all times, being many times greater than the rate from the country of export to the port of arrival in Turkey and often amounting to much more than the original cost of the goods. This region can never make much progress commercially until transportation conditions are remedied by the building of railroads, and this is not likely to be done except with foreign capital and assistance.

Housing Conditions—Military Exoneration Tax.

Owing to the lack of building stone and almost total lack of wood of any kind in this part of Turkey, all houses in both town and country are built of mud bricks called “kerpitch,” which is a mixture of mud and straw. The houses are not large and part of them is always used for the stable, one or two rooms only being reserved for the use of the family, which lives in the simplest and most primitive manner. Every one sleeps rolled up in a blanket on the earth floor. The only fuel used by the majority of the population is manure dried in the sun. Among people accustomed to this manner of living it can not be expected that there will be much market for foreign goods. The lot of the people is made worse by uncertain economic conditions and recent political unrest. The exoneration tax of 43 Turkish pounds gold (\$189.20) levied on those who have been excused from military service in the present war represents the life savings of the majority of the people who have paid it.

Yet a certain amount of progress is to be noted. Many of the inhabitants have been to the United States. They have naturally brought back some new ideas, and as a result there is a slowly growing demand for certain articles. Most conspicuous is the increase in the sale of cheap ready-made and second-hand clothing. A large portion of these goods now comes from the United States. The total imports in 1914 amounted to about \$25,000, as compared with \$6,500 in the previous year. There is also a slight demand for metal roofing, the imports of which amounted to \$8,800 in 1914, as compared with \$750 in 1913.

Business Situation During the Early Part of Last Year.

Trade in this district was not especially good at the beginning of 1914. It is allways dull in the interior of Turkey during the winter months. The depression was greater than usual, however, as the country had not recovered financially from its two recent wars.

After the French loan was negotiated and the first payment received the prospects were brighter. Concessions were granted in connection with this loan for the construction of a railroad between Samsun, on the Black Sea coast, and various points in the interior of Asia Minor, and work was actually begun at Samsun. As much of the region between Samsun and Harput is very fertile and at the present time it is impossible to export the crops because of lack of means of transportation to the coast, the people

were looking forward to a new era. The telegraph and mail services had already been greatly improved. During the spring and early summer there was much building activity at Harput and many new houses were in process of erection. In July the streets here were publicly lighted for the first time. At Sivas plans were made to establish an electric-light plant. Crops everywhere were unusually good and after the trade depression of the first half of the year a revival of business was anticipated for the autumn. The building activity resulted in an increased demand for some building materials. Shopkeepers and merchants were on their way to Constantinople to replenish their stocks, when suddenly a general mobilization of the Turkish Army was declared.

Trade ceased, as many merchants and tradesmen had to join the army. Harvesting was left largely to the women and children and a considerable portion of the crops was lost. Grain, animals, and goods of all kinds were requisitioned by the Government. Money was withdrawn from circulation and the banks refused to make payments.

Large Decrease in Import Trade.

The import and export trade of this region in 1914 was therefore practically limited to the first seven months of the year. The imports, however, during that period were greater than usual, due largely to the fact that this city has recently been made the headquarters of an army corps and increased business was anticipated. The total value of the imports in 1914 was \$1,525,720, as compared with \$2,194,450 in 1913. Of the imports in 1914, goods from abroad amounted to \$1,038,660 and goods from other parts of Turkey to \$487,060.

The values of the principal imports from foreign countries into the Vilayet of Mamouret-ul-Aziz for 1913 and 1914 and the principal countries of origin for 1914 are shown in the following table (United States, U. S.; Austria, Aus.; Belgium, Bel.; France, Fr.; Germany, Ger.; Greece, Gr.; Italy, It.; Netherlands, Neth.; Russia, Rus.; Sweden, Sw.; Switzerland, Switz.; United Kingdom, U. K.):

Articles.	1913	1914	Countries of origin, 1914.
Arms and ammunition	\$4,000	\$1,000	Bel., U. S., Ger., Fr., Aus.
Books	1,800	1,100	Fr., U. S., Ger.

Candles	3,500	3,000	Aus., Ger., Fr.
Chemicals, dyes, etc.:			
Alizarin, anilin, and artificial indigo	18,000	5,000	Ger., Aus.
Indigo	1,200	3,500	India.
Clocks and watches	4,000	3,000	Aus., Ger., Fr., Switz., U. S.
Clothing	6,500	25,000	U. S., Fr.
Coffee	9,000	3,500	Brazil, Arabia
Copper, sheet	10,000	5,000	U. K.
Cotton goods:			
Cabots	6,100	66,000	U. K., It., Ger., Aus., U. S.
Calicoes	50,000	44,000	U. K., It., Ger., Aus., Rus.
Flannel	35,000	11,000	It., Aus., Bel., Neth., U. K.
Handkerchiefs	10,000	2,200	U. K., Aus., Ger.
Prints	13,000	35,000	U. K., It., Rus.
Sheetings	71,000	80,000	U. K., It., Neth.
Yarn	165,000	110,000	U. K., India.
Other	80,000	88,000	U. K., It., Aus., Ger., Bel.
Crockery	1,800	3,500	Aus., Ger., It., Fr.
Drugs	3,800	7,000	U. K., Fr., U. S., Ger.
Enameled ware	2,400	11,000	Aus., Ger.
Fezzes	45,000	15,000	Aus.
Glass and glassware	6,200	8,800	Aus., Ger., U. S.
Grammaphones and supplies	400		
Hides, buffalo	65,000	88,000	India, China.
Iron and steel manufactures of:			
Agricultural implements	2,500	2,200	U. S., U. K., Ger., Aus.
Hardware	9,000	4,400	Ger., Aus., U. S.
Machinery—			
Ginning	1,000		
Printing	500		
Other	8,900	2,000	U. K., U. S.
Nails	7,000	17,600	U. K., Aus., Bel.
Roofing, metal	750	8,800	Fr., U. S.
Sheet iron	5,000	8,800	Fr., U. K.
Shovels	1,500	4,400	Do.
Tools	1,700	880	U. S., Ger.
Water pipes	500		
Other	14,600	8,500	Bel., Aus., Ger., Sw., Neth., U. S.
Jewelry	6,500	5,000	Aus., It., Ger.
Leather	11,000	8,800	Fr., Ger., Gr.
Matches	20,000	15,000	Aus., It.
Mercer's goods	44,000	13,200	Aus., U. K., It.
Paper			

Cigarette	9,000	15,000	Aus., Fr., Ger.
Other	12,500	10,000	Aus., Ger., U. K., Bel.
Perfumes	1,000	300	Fr., Ger.
Petroleum	61,000	25,000	Rus., Roumania, U. S.
Rubber overshoes and goods	5,000	4,400	U. S.
Sacks and sacking	6,000	5,000	U. K.
Spices	5,000	5,000	India.
Sugar	52,000	25,000	Aus., Rus., Egypt.
Tea	2,000	880	U. K., Rus.
Tin	6,600		U. K.
Velvet	14,000	4,400	U. K., It.
Woolen goods:			
Underwear	5,500	6,600	Ger., Aus.
Other	380,000	175,000	U. K., Fr., Ger., Aus., Bel.
All other articles	60,000	42,000	
Total	1,360,750	1,038,000	

The imports into the Vilayet of Mamouret-ul-Aziz from other parts of Turkey during 1014 were valued at \$487,060, compared with \$833,700 for 1013. The imported articles and their value for two years were as follows:

Articles.	1913	1914
Aniseed	\$3,500	\$3,500
Butter	150,000	132,000
Copperware	45,000	5,000
Flour	2,000	1,760
Henna	1,500	2,200
Horseshoes	4,000	3,500
Ornaments, gold and silver	4,800	3,500
Rice	17,000	26,400
Salt	145,000	30,000
Shares, plow (native make)	1,500	880
School supplies	5,000	2,500
Sheetings	4,400	4,400
Sheep and goats	280,000	180,000
Soap	85,000	17,600
Timber	5,000	5,000
Tobacco	34,500	26,400
Towels	3,500	1,760
All other articles	42,000	40,660
Total	833,700	487,060

Effect of War on Export Trade.

The effect of the disturbed conditions on the export trade was much worse, as most of the articles exported from here are agricultural products and are not shipped until the latter part of the year. By that time all animals that could be used for transport were requisitioned for the army and shipments either abroad or to other parts of Turkey were impossible. Consequently, the export trade to foreign countries from this Vilayet in 1914 amounted to only \$137,100, as compared with \$494,390 in 1913, and the value of shipments to other Provinces of Turkey to \$139,600, as compared with \$599,740 in 1913—a total of only \$276,700 in 1914, whereas the total exports in 1913 amounted to \$1,094,130. These exports were as follows:

Articles.	1913	1914
TO FOREIGN COUNTRIES.		
Apricot stones:		
Bitter	\$6,000	
Sweet	8,000	
Cocoons	8,500	
Cotton	47,300	\$60,000
Embroideries	20,000	1,000
Fruits, dried	16,000	
Furs	19,000	
Goatskins	22,000	
Leather, morocco	39,00	
Nuts:		
Pistachio	12,000	
Other	12,000	
Opium	190,740	75,000
Raisins	35,000	
Rugs and kilims	20,000	
Sausage casings	9,300	1,100
Silkworm eggs	19,800	
Other articles	9,750	
Total	494,390	137,100
TO TURKISH PROVINCES.		

Almonds	\$6,500	
Apricots, dried	42,000	\$440
Butter	6,500	
Cotton prints	3,000	26,400
Cotton	96,000	20,000
Cord and ropes	8,000	660
Fruits	25,000	22,000
Goatskins	75,000	2,000
Hides	7,000	5,000
Leather, morocco	18,000	2,200
Manoosa (cotton cloth)	180,000	30,000
Raisins	39,000	2,500
Silk cloth	8,000	3,500
Silk, raw	6,000	
All other articles	79,740	24,900
Total	599,740	139,600

The foregoing figures are estimates made after interviewing all the leading merchants and shopkeepers in this region. No official trade statistics are kept in the interior of Turkey.

The only declared exports from this consular district to the United States during 1914 was a shipment of household goods and personal effects, valued at \$92, made by a missionary, who was returning home.

Advance in Prices of Necessaries.

The greatest decrease in imports was in the necessities of life, such as petroleum, soap, sugar, coffee, tea, and woolen goods. The prices of these commodities have consequently increased considerably and are continuing to rise. The Government has endeavored to remedy this condition by ordering merchants to sell their wares at reasonable prices.

The prices of kerosene has advanced from 80 to 200 piasters a box (two tins), soap from 9 to 10 piasters an oke (a piaster is equivalent to 4.4 cents and an oke to 2.82 pounds), sugar from 4 to 10 piasters an oke, coffee from 15 to 36 piasters an oke, and tea from 5 to 10 piasters a box, while the prices of clothes, shoes, and other articles of wearing apparel have increased on an average about 50 per cent.

Trade Opportunities Along Certain Lines.

Notwithstanding the limited means of the people of this district and its small trade, there is a slight market here for some kinds of goods. These opportunities are undoubtedly increased to some extent by the present situation, which has cut off many of the former sources of supply, and when means of transportation are again available tradesmen will have to replenish their stocks.

Among articles formerly obtained from European countries that might be supplied by the United States are candles, cigarette paper, copper (sheet), enameled iron and steel ware, fezzes, matches, nails, sheet iron, shovels, and sugar. The market for sugar is especially good, and there is also a considerable demand for enameled ware, the sale of which is increasing rapidly, and for nails and shovels.

Demand for Cotton Goods.

The sale of many articles now imported in limited quantities from the United States may readily be increased. Most important are cotton goods, especially cabots. On investigation it was found that these are sold in this district in much greater quantities than was previously supposed. It is believed that if proper arrangements could be made, American cabots might take the place, to a great extent, of those now imported from other countries. The American cabot "A" is well known in Turkey and is extensively used both in the army and among the people. Any cabot to be sold here must be cheap and durable. There is also a good market for calicoes and prints. Calicoes must be unstarched and prints must be of fast colors. Bright colors with large flower designs are preferred; prints having animal designs would not sell here. Large quantities of yarn are used, especially in the region of Arabkir, in the manufacture of a cotton cloth called "manoosa," which is made and worn throughout Asia Minor. In the past practically all the yarn has come from England and India. Care should be taken about sizes, as only certain numbers are used, and only English numbers are understood. Remnants of gingham, calicoes, ribbons, or any other textile articles would have a good sale here.

Increased Market for Second-Hand Clothing, Shoes, Knit Underwear, etc.

Other articles of wearing apparel that are now imported from the United States in small quantities might be sold more extensively. The rapid increase in the sale of second-hand clothing is an indication of the possibilities in this line. The dealers in these goods have no difficulty in selling all they can get and report a growing demand for them, due largely to the return of many Armenians who have lived in the United States. The men in this region are gradually discarding their native “entari” (a union waist and skirt, in appearance like a woman’s dress) for modern clothes, which they find more convenient. Style is of less consideration than cheapness. One frequently sees men wearing second-hand women’s jackets.

American shoes are worn here to some extent, and there is a fair market for shoes that sell for not more than \$2 or \$8. There is also a growing demand for rubber overshoes, nearly all of which now come from the United States. Owing to the present lack of transportation facilities they are being imported by post.

Knit underwear is beginning to be worn, but only by the better classes. As they comprise only a small portion of the population, the market for this line of goods is limited.

Parasols are always carried by the higher-class Turkish and Armenian women, principally for the purpose of concealing their faces. Bright colors are always chosen.

Some improvement is to be noted in the styles of women’s dresses. Woolen dress goods are now sold here. Medium qualities of durable material sell best. This is not as important a market for other woollen goods as might appear from the import statistics, as only the cheapest kinds can be sold.

Among other articles for which there is some market might be mentioned buttons, celluloid collars, suspenders, and thread.

Government Encouraging the Use of Improved Agricultural Implements.

There is a great need of certain kinds of agricultural implements in this district. Agriculture is practically its only industry, but it is carried on in the most primitive manner with crude wooden and iron plows and other implements of local manufacture. The Government has been making some effort, however, to introduce modern farming implements, and maintains in

all the principal cities in the interior of Asia Minor supply stations where they are sold at cost and free instruction given in their use. Only the cheapest and simplest kinds of implements can be sold. Much of the land is rough and stony, and oxen are used instead of horses.

There is a limited market for hardware and for simple carpenters' and blacksmiths' tools, such as axes, hammers, hatchets, drills, files, planes, screw drivers, saws, hinges, locks, latches, staples, chains, wire, wire nails, knives, forks, spoons, pocketknives, scissors, clippers, currycombs, small coffee mills, and meat choppers. The last are used by nearly every one in preparing a favorite native dish of chopped meat called "kufte." Until recently nearly all the above-mentioned articles used here have been of local make, but foreign-made goods are gradually taking their places. American sewing machines have a good sale. There has also been some demand for American metal roofing.

Other Articles that Might Find a Market.

Among other articles for which there is some market in this district, only a small portion of which now comes from the United States, are bicycles, canned fish, clocks and watches, drugs, glass and glassware, lamps, lanterns, needles and pins, petroleum, second-hand saddles, shoe polish, soap, stationery, toys, and wooden shoe pegs. The sale of drugs is rapidly increasing, due partly to the many Armenians here who have become accustomed to their use in the United States, and also to the American hospitals in the district, all of which maintain public dispensaries. The sale of American petroleum has recently begun in this region; formerly nearly all came from Russia and Roumania.

There is no market worth seeking in this district for such articles as automobiles, electrical or other machinery, engines, motor boats, musical instruments, or office furniture, though there is an occasional isolated purchase. One automobile was ordered last June through this consulate, but owing to the outbreak of war its shipment has been indefinitely delayed.

Plans were being made for the installation of an electric-light plant at Sivas, but the undertaking has been stopped by the war. This would have been the first one in the interior of Asia Minor.

Effect of Emigration on Business—Money Sent from United States.

One advantage that American firms have in doing business here is that a large number of Armenians from this district have been to the United States. They have become familiar with articles of American manufacture and are useful agents in advertising their merits. Most of them understand English. Some of them buy small shops in the market and start in business for themselves. They naturally favor American goods. Others engage in some trade in which they employ American tools.

Local bankers estimate that nearly \$1,000,000, or \$10 per family, comes into this one Vilayet annually from emigrants who have settled in the United States. The importance of this revenue to the poor people here can be appreciated from the fact that the average family lives on about \$150 a year. Many are wholly dependent on money sent them by relatives in the United States. Great hardship is being caused, therefore, by the present situation, as it is practically impossible to send money here.

The only industry of importance in this district is agriculture, and the prosperity of the region depends on the success of the crops. The farmers, who constitute a large part of the population, realized but little on the crops, owing partly to the abundance of yield, the decreased demand on account of the departure of large numbers of men for the army, and the scarcity of money. These conditions, however, benefited those living in the towns and cities.

Wheat sold in 1013 for 50 or 60 piasters per kile (a piaster is equivalent to 4.4 cents and a kile to about 170 pounds) and barley for 35 piasters per kile. Last year wheat sold as low as 35 piasters per kile and barley as low as 25 piasters per kile.

Increased Yield of Cotton.

Considerable cotton of an inferior quality is raised in this Vilayet. The bolls are about the size of a walnut, the fiber short, and the plants small. Other varieties do not thrive here on account of the shortness of the season. The method of cultivation is primitive, most of the work being performed by women, and little effort is made to secure good crops.

It is estimated that last year's yield will amount to between 1,400,000 and 1,600,000 pounds, which is greater than it was in 1013; but as the ginning is done very slowly with small machines, not more than 40,000 or 50,000 pounds had actually been brought to the market by the end of the year.

None arrived until December and it is probable that the full crop will not be received before May or June. No cotton is being exported at the present time, but last year about \$60,000 worth of the 1913 crop went to Russia, and about \$20,000 worth to other Provinces of Turkey. About 250,000 pounds of cotton are sold in this Vilayet each year to be used in making rough cotton cloth and native prints. This year, however, owing to the impossibility of exportation and to the difficulty of importing cotton goods, much more than that amount will probably be used in making native cloth. The price of last season's cotton when it was first received was 20 piasters a batman (about 5 cents a pound). By the end of December it had advanced to 30 piasters a batman (7 cents a pound). The average price here is 35 or 40 piasters a batman (84 to 91 cents a pound).

Production of Silk, Opium, and Fruit.

The cultivation of silkworms is carried on in nearly every village of the district. There are a number of small silk factories and most of the production of this industry is used locally, but usually some cocoons are exported each year to Marseille and some silkworm eggs to Russia, Persia, and Roumania, while raw silk goes to several of the other Provinces of Turkey. Last year there were no exports abroad in this line and very little, if anything, sent to other Provinces. The production of cocoons in this Vilayet was only about half what it was in 1913, amounting to about 100,000 pounds (making 10,000 or 11,000 pounds of raw silk). One-fourth of this amount was used by one factory, the only one of any size in the district, but this is now closed because there is no market for its goods. A small amount was used by a few other small factories and the remainder is on hand. The amount of eggs last season was 30,000 ounces, the same as in 1913, of which 5,000 ounces were used here and the remainder is on hand.

The yield of opium last year was practically the same as in 1913, amounting to about 17,000 okes (47,000 pounds), all of it being produced in Malatia. Only about half of this amount, valued at \$75,000, has been exported. The price fluctuated considerably last season, varying from \$1.50 to \$5 per pound. The average price here is about \$4 per pound.

The fruit crop last year was much less than usual, as the trees were badly damaged by hailstorms in May and much of the fruit destroyed before it was ripe. There was only about half an average crop of almonds, grapes,

apples, pears, and plums. The price of almonds, however, is only 9 piasters an oke (13 cents a pound), about half the usual price, because none were exported. The crop of apricots was about average, and the peach crop only a little below the average.

Lack of Fuel—Machinery for Artesian Well.

The lack of fuel is one of the greatest problems of this region. The only wood obtainable is scrub oak sapplings, all of which has to be brought here on the backs of donkeys from a distance of two or three or even four days' journey. The price is advancing each year as the supply is getting scarcer and the wood brought from greater distances. There is no way by which coal or wood could be brought here from other places. The recent discovery of a deposit of coal in the Paloo region, two days' journey from Harput, aroused hopes that this problem might be partially solved, but the coal has proved to be of inferior quality and hardly worth bringing here.

The machinery for the artesian well mentioned in the last two annual reports from this consulate was recently set up and drilling has begun under the direction of a native engineer, but as yet without results.

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TURKEY, HARPUT *****

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